

Unwritten

written by

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DREAM - INT. KITCHEN - NIGHT

The kitchen is still, humming softly.
Warm yellow light pools on pale tile. Everything feels gentle
and quiet.

ELENA(27, but we never see her face) stands at the counter.
She adjusts a bouquet of roses in a vase.
They're uneven. She turns the stems. Again. Again.

A single petal drops.

She reaches to pick it up.

Behind her, faint at first – then louder:

CHILD (O.S.)

Mommy?

(beat)

Mommy!!

The word hits something in her, and she startles.
Her elbow knocks the vase.
The vase falls over.
Water floods the countertop. The flowers scatter.
A grocery list soaks. An envelope darkens as ink bleeds.

She freezes for a second, then turns toward the hallway.
We follow only her back as she walks away, fast.

The roses lie half-submerged, face-down in their own water.

CUT TO:

INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT (PRESENT)

MIRA (21) and LEAH (21) sit on the bed, each wrapped their
head in blankets. Between them: a half-eaten bag of chips,
scattered laundry, and two mugs. The room feels paused in
time – childhood posters, a dusty desk lamp, an unopened
suitcase slumped in the corner.

LEAH

Ok my turn.
Would you rather... have fingers
for eyelashes or eyelashes for
fingers?

MIRA

Absolutely not.

LEAH

No escaping. You play or you
unpack.

MIRA

(sighs)

Eyelashes for fingers. Better for typing.

LEAH

Ew. Imagine mascara.

she shudders.

MIRA

Ok my turn.

(thinking for a beat)

Would you rather... be stuck in high school forever, or skip to being 35?

LEAH

Definitely 35. No braces, no crushes on straight girls. Just me, my mortgage and my hot wife.

MIRA

That's optimistic.
I'd choose high school.

LEAH

Please, you were insufferable in high school.

MIRA

Excuse you. I was mysterious.

LEAH

You wore headphones with no music to avoid conversations.

MIRA

Ok to be fair.
I still do that sometimes.

LEAH

You're unbelievable.

There's some noise coming from downstairs. Footsteps. Drawer opens and closes. Then silence again. They both listen intently.

They both start whispering when they start talking about Mira's dad.

LEAH (CONT'D)

Is that your dad?

MIRA

It's either him or a ghost.

LEAH

What does he even do all day?

MIRA

I don't know. He goes to work most of the day. Then... I guess he watches the news with the sound off. Moves things around the kitchen and pretends he's cleaning.

LEAH

Pretends?

MIRA

Yeah. Like... he opens the fridge, stares inside, closes it.

LEAH

That's kinda sad.

Mira shrugs.

LEAH (CONT'D)

In that case, would you rather live alone in a house or live with someone who never really talks to you?

MIRA

Jesus. What happened to hot wife and mascara fingers?

LEAH

Balance. I contain multitudes.

MIRA

(think hard for a beat)
I seriously don't know how to answer this.

LEAH

Come on. It's just a game.

MIRA

I'm bad at choosing.

LEAH

No kidding. You spent a whole semester deciding whether to text someone or not.

MIRA

It should be a strategic and
thought-through decision.

They both laugh, then get quieter.

MIRA (CONT'D)

I can't believe that was three
years ago.

LEAH

I know. How can it be the last
winter break?
Okay—would you rather relive all of
college, every class, every 8 a.m.,
or skip ahead to... like, whatever
your adult life ends up being?

MIRA

A hundred percent college.

LEAH

Damn even the group projects part?

MIRA

I just can't imagine what's gonna
happen without... all of it, the
structure. The permission to not
know anything. How am I supposed to
know what I'm gonna do, and... pick
a path and... have it all together.

LEAH

I thought you were going to grad
school.

MIRA

Yeah, maybe.

(beat)

I don't even know how to write my
thesis now.

LEAH

Speaking of which.
Would you rather finish your
thesis, or spontaneously combust?

MIRA

Ugh, kill me now.

LEAH

Still stuck?

MIRA
Don't remind me.

LEAH
What is it about again?

MIRA
It's called "A Kind of Saying
Nothing: Silence, Subjectivity, and
the Epistolary Voice."

LEAH
Sexy.

MIRA
I don't know what to do with it
now!

LEAH
Don't worry so much. You'll figure
it out, eventually.

MIRA
How are you so sure all the time?

LEAH
(shrugs)
I just know.

MIRA
Alright. Last one.

LEAH
Hit me.

MIRA
Would you rather help a close,
beloved friend survive the crushing
weight of her unfinished thesis by
accompanying her to the library
tomorrow... or be a terrible
person?

LEAH
Wow that wasn't even subtle.

MIRA
Subtlety is for people who aren't 3
weeks behind schedule.
(beat)
Come on, come on, I'm desperate --

LEAH
Fine. But only if you buy me food.

They continue talking, but the sounds become muffled as the camera moves out of the room.

EXT. SUBURBAN STREET - DAY

Late morning. The kind of pale winter sun that makes everything feel lifeless. Mira and Leah walk down the street toward the local library. Mira is carrying a tote bag, half-filled notebooks peeking out. Leah is eating a croissant. Her voice is a little muffled with her mouth full.

LEAH

It's freezing oh my god why why why
did I agree to help you dig through
dusty books about sad women?

MIRA

Because you love me.
And because of this.

Mira points at Leah's croissant.

LEAH

Fair.
(beat)
So, what are we looking for today?

MIRA

Maybe some lesser-read Woolf, her
letters to Violet. And some
unpublished correspondence. You
know, women who weren't trying to
be read.

LEAH

Gosh what was the last time people
even wrote letters.
(looks at Mira)
Did your mom ever?

MIRA

I don't really remember much. But I
don't think so. Letter-writing is
too romantic for her. She was
more...get-it-done. Lists, errands
kind of person. She worked in
pharma, so nothing flowery.

LEAH

*And now her daughter is digging for
letters nobody cares about.*

MIRA
Life's funny like that.

Mira pushes the library door open.

INT. LIBRARY - DAY

Mira and Leah move between the shelves. Mira trails a finger along faded spines. They stopped in front of a shelf. Mira pulls out a book.

MIRA
(murmur)
Here. Volume 5...

LEAH
Volume 5? How much can a woman write!

MIRA
You'd be amazed. She writes like she's trying to prove she existed.
(beat)

LEAH
(looks at the shelves full of books)
I can't believe these people wrote so much when no one was reading.

MIRA
Sometimes I think that's the only time they told the truth.

MIRA (CONT'D)
For instance look at this,

Mira points at the page to show Leah.

MIRA (CONT'D)
(reads from the page)
"Watered the violets. The one near the fence bloomed late again."
(beat)
That's not about gardening.

LEAH
I don't understand.

MIRA
It's not for us to understand, it's for the right person to recognize.

Mira continues to read.

She shuts her book. Stares at nothing for a beat.

MIRA (CONT'D)

Why am I trying to turn this into a thesis...

LEAH

What's wrong?

MIRA

I don't know. It just feels like I'm gonna write the same stuff I always do, like I'm just rewording what we've already said in class a thousand times.

She flips back and forth, restless.

MIRA (CONT'D)

*(murmuring to herself,
slowly)*

How do you write a silence?

The sounds of the library – pages turning, a distant chair scraping – fill the space between them. Mira closes the book.

INT. STUDY - DAY

MIRA sits at her desk, hunched slightly forward. Elbow propped up, cheek buried in her palm.

She's reading a printed draft of her thesis – the pages dog-eared and scribbled on. A long, academic title sits at the top. We can't quite read it, but it looks long and serious.

She flips to a page midway through. Skims a paragraph. Frowns.

MIRA

(murmuring)

"...the domestic enclosure as an archive of silence..."

Ugh. God, you sound like a citation machine.

She scribbles something in the margin. Crosses it out. Scribbles again. Pauses. Then violently crosses out the whole paragraph.

She exhales, frustrated, tosses her pen across the desk. It clatters to the floor.

She leans back. Eyes on the ceiling. Silence. Her fingers tap her knee, a restless rhythm.

She glances at her laptop. A browser tab is open, it's about PhD application.

She feels really tired and exasperated just looking at that, and slams the laptop shut.

She stands. Crosses to the bookshelf. Runs her fingers across the spines.

Still unsettled, she crosses to a cabinet – one she rarely opens. She crouches, opens one drawer after the other, then when she opens the bottom drawer, she pauses.

There's a small box. Sealed by tape. She pulls it out. Brings it to the desk.

A long beat as she sits. Her breath slows.

She peels back the tape.

Inside: letters. Some yellowed. Some in envelopes. Some loose.

She lifts the first letter and unfolds it, and reads in silence.

MIRA (CONT'D)
(reading softly, to
herself)
" Dear Rebecca, hi how are you
doing...
(reads for a beat)
tell me about the world as you see
it...
(reads for a beat)
Yours... Will"

She stares at the page, then looks down at the pile. So many pages.

She places the letter gently on top of her thesis, and pulls the rest of the letters closer.

She looks out the window. A quiet beat.

FADE OUT.

INT. STUDY - LATER THAT DAY

The door creaks open. Leah steps in with two mugs in hand. She spots Mira on the floor, surrounded by books and loose papers, a few open boxes nearby.

LEAH
I brought tea.
(she nudges the door half-shut)
And also... What the hell is going on here?

MIRA
(holds up a letter)
I... found these.

LEAH
(crouching beside her)
Are those letters?

MIRA
Yeah. They're from my dad. All addressed to someone named Rebecca.

LEAH
A woman? Do you know her?

MIRA
Not at all. But there are replies. A lot of them. It's like... a whole conversation.

LEAH
Wait—if they were mailing each other, why does your dad still have the letters he sent?

MIRA
Exactly. That's the weird part.

LEAH
When are they from?

MIRA
(She looks for the first letter and holds it up)
The first one was from...
(take a look)
2003. Look, here it is.

She hands Mira the letter.

MIRA (CONT'D)

She said something about how they didn't end things properly and she asked if he'd meet her at a café.

LEAH

(takes the letter and
looks at it)

Wow, okay.

Does it sound like flirting?

MIRA

A little bit.

(beat)

And my dad replied in 2004, one year later. The year before I was born.

LEAH

(reluctant to say it out
loud)

You think they were... involved?

MIRA

I don't know.

(quiet)

Is that the most possible conclusion?

LEAH

What does it look like now?

MIRA

I haven't finished reading everything yet.

(beat)

But it's strange. They're not romantic, exactly. They're just... intimate.

LEAH

Are you actually gonna ask him?

MIRA

Arghhhh isn't it so weird? Asking your dad if he was having a secret pen-pal affair?

LEAH

So weird.

(sips tea)

But why do you even care? They're just old letters.

MIRA

Because... I don't know. They feel important.

LEAH

Then, unfortunately, you're gonna have to ask.

MIRA

Arghhh...
It's always so awkward with my dad. I was almost never left alone with him until my mom...died. And now we don't really talk.

LEAH

Ugh. Dads. My dad once asked if I was 'still doing the gay thing.'

MIRA

You're kidding.

LEAH

Unfortunately no.

They sit in silence for a beat. Mira flips through another letter.

MIRA

It's just so weird.
(beat)
Like we live in the same house but it still feels like we're strangers.

LEAH

Yeah. But maybe these letters may be the closest thing to him saying something real.

MIRA

Maybe.

Mira lies down for a moment, then sits up.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

WILL (46) sits slouched on the couch, TV remote in hand. Light from the screen flickers over him.

Mira hovers at the threshold, clutching a small bundle of letters. She hesitates, then steps in.

MIRA

Dad?

WILL

Yeah? Is the TV too loud?

MIRA

No, it's fine.

She perches on the far end of the couch, letters hidden in her lap. A small, uncomfortable pause. The TV hums.

Will glances over, sensing something.

WILL

Everything okay, kiddo?

MIRA

Yeah. Just... needed a break from my thesis.

He nods, half-smiles.

WILL

Sounds heavy.

Awkward silence.

MIRA

Can I ask you something random?

WILL

Shoot.

MIRA

Do you know someone named Rebecca?

WILL

Rebecca? Rebecca who?

MIRA

I'm not sure... Does that name ring a bell at all?

WILL

(trying to recall)

Yeah. Yeah, actually I do know one Rebecca. Wow. That's a name I haven't heard in a while. I dated a Rebecca in college.

(MORE)

WILL (CONT'D)

(beat)

Where is this coming from?

MIRA

I think I saw the name somewhere.
Like, on a photo in Mom's desk
drawer or something. It's just
stuck in my head.

WILL

Huh, that's odd.

MIRA

So, what kind of person is she?

WILL

(recalling)

The Rebecca from college? I
remember she was very into
literature. Painting. That kind of
thing. Taught me a lot about art.

MIRA

Were you two close?

WILL

We were twenty. Everything feels
close at that age. But no, it
didn't last. We broke up before I
started working.

Mira looks down, absorbing that.

MIRA

Did you two ever talk after you
broke up?

WILL

(recalling)

No, not since graduation.

MIRA

(nods slowly)

Right.

She glances at the TV but doesn't really see it.

WILL

Why the sudden interest?

MIRA

No reason. Just got curious I
guess.

She stares at the TV for a moment too long. The air between them feels distant and awkward.

MIRA (CONT'D)
Anyway, I should go to bed.

WILL
G'night, kiddo.

She stands, the smile on her face not quite matching her eyes.

MIRA
Night.

She walks away.

CUT TO:

INT. MIRA'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Mira quickly closes the door behind her. she stands for a second and takes out the letters.

She sits on the edge of the bed. Carefully unfolds the page.

MIRA
(softly, to herself)
Not your voice.

She reads.

Cut between snippets of the letter and her face — the growing awareness, confusion, and dawning understanding.

MIRA (CONT'D)
(reading the letters
quickly, murmuring)
"Dear Rebecca, the garden looks
better now that I've trimmed the
hedges. My wife wanted to hire
someone, but I did it myself. It
felt grounding."

Mira frowns. She flips to another page.

MIRA (CONT'D)
"There's a new bakery near the
pharmacy. I bought the wrong kind
of bread — she likes sourdough, not
rye."

She flips to another page.

MIRA (CONT'D)

"My wife and I had dinner with some friends last night. I can't remember what we talked about. We smiled through most of it. That counts as happy, I think."

MIRA (CONT'D)

(to herself)

You don't write like this.

She opens a drawer. Pulls out one of her old birthday cards, one signed by her dad, generic and casual.

She places it beside the letter. The handwriting doesn't match.

She opens one more.

MIRA (CONT'D)

"It snowed today. The kind that doesn't stick. Every time it snowed I think of the story *The Snow Queen* — the one where the glass gets stuck in your eye, and suddenly you can't see anything clearly anymore."

A beat. Mira's breath catches.

She runs to the drawer again, then from the deeper end of the drawer she draws another card, buried deep in her things.

It's a birthday card written by her mother.

She cross checks the handwriting, they match. A dawning understanding washing over her.

MIRA (CONT'D)

It was you.

Then a knock at the door.

LEAH (O.S.)

You okay?

Mira doesn't answer right away. She places the letter carefully back into the envelope.

MIRA

Yeah. Just... reading.

LEAH (O.S.)

Want company?

Mira glances at the stack, then at her hands.

MIRA
Give me five minutes.

She stares down at the letters, her mother's letters, pretending to be someone else.

A whole life, rewritten in someone else's voice.

She closes her eyes.

INT. BEDROOM - DAY(2004)

This is another timeline, when ELENA(24, Mira's mom) was young. They lived in the same house as now. The bedroom decoration should show that it's 2004.

A stream of sunshine fell on Elena's face. She suddenly opened her eyes. She should be sleeping on one side of the bed, showing that someone slept right next to her before and had already left. She doesn't look energetic, or excited about the day, or anything. She sits up.

ELENA
(murmur)
Oh no it's Wednesday...

Elena gets out of bed and walks out quickly.

INT. SUPERMARKET - DAY

Elena walks in between two aisles, quickly grabbing things from the shelf and puts them in the cart. She does everything so fast and mechanically and with practiced efficiency.

INT. DINING ROOM - NIGHT

A warmly lit room. Clinking silverware. A very adult occasion.

Around the table: GRACE (extravagant, sharp-edged), HENRY (Grace's husband), KAREN (a little smug), MARK (Karen's husband always smiling). Polished people with polished lives. They're all dressed nicely and treat each other with practiced, fake politeness.

GRACE
(exaggerated)
So, Henry and I finally decided to redo the kitchen.
(MORE)

GRACE (CONT'D)

Quartz countertops, heated floors.
I told him, if we're going to host,
I want it to feel like we're
in *Architectural Digest*.

KAREN

Good luck with that. Those
renovations always take twice as
long as they say.

GRACE

Oh, we know. But what can you do? A
house like ours needs upkeep.

Light laughter. Wine poured.

Laughter. Elena smiles faintly but doesn't speak. She pushes
a slice of food around her plate, untouched.

She glances at the others. Their smiles are too polished, too
bright. She watches them – really watches them.

Grace flicks her hair as she laughs.

Two beats later, Karen does the exact same thing.

Henry dabs at his mouth. A second later, Will does too.

It repeats like choreography. Offbeat, but rehearsed.

The conversation blurs into noise. Forks clink. A glass
clinks too loudly. Laughter loops once, too loud, too hollow.

The voices begin to muffle. Not gone, just distant. Like
Elena is underwater.

Her gaze travels slowly around the table.

GRACE (CONT'D)

(to Elena)

You're lucky Will has that study to
hide in. Henry just messes up the
dining table.

Elena smiles politely.

HENRY

(to Will)

Do you still keep your old sketch
books in there?

WILL

Maybe buried deep somewhere. I
don't really draw anymore.

KAREN

Wait, seriously? You used to fill those notebooks like it was a full-time job.

GRACE

Yeah, all those little drawings. I remember you showing me one of Rebecca. That side profile one, her looking out the window? — when was that, sophomore year?

Elena looks up hearing the name.

ELENA

Rebecca?

GRACE

Oh, old friend from college. She used to hang out with us all the time. And then she moved to... I don't know, France?

A beat. Grace glances at Will.

Will doesn't respond. Elena keeps looking at him. The others shift awkwardly.

GRACE (CONT'D)

That sketch was beautiful though. You really captured something.

The conversation moves on, but Elena keeps thinking about what was said.

MARK

Work's good, Will?

WILL

Busy. Which I guess is good.

HENRY

Busy means you're not dispensable. That's how I see it.

GRACE

And kids? When are we going to see little ones running around here?

More laughter. Louder this time.

Elena's fork pauses. Her stomach tightens.

She glances at Will. He doesn't look up.

MARK

Will talked about wanting kids
since college.
We used to bet he'd be the first
one to be a dad.

More laughter.

Elena blinks. She didn't know that.

WILL

Well, we've just been busy.

KAREN

Don't wait too long. It gets
harder. And louder.

MARK

We say we're waiting for the right
moment, but no one ever knows when
that is.

GRACE

Speaking of kids - Tim's been a
handful lately. The school called
again about his behavior. Henry
says it's just a phase, but
honestly...

The conversation drifts. Glasses clink. Names are dropped.

Elena floats outside of it, suspended.

She looks at Will from across the table, puzzled.

INT. LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Shot from the living room, it's dark other than the light
coming from the kitchen, there's water sound.

The water sound stops. Elena walks out of the kitchen. Then
stands still and starts stretching. She seems tired.

INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

Elena walks into the room, the room is dark. The only light
comes from the hallway.

Will is lying on the bed, his back facing the door.

WILL
(mumble)
Good night. You did such a
wonderful job.

Elena walks to the bed and lies down. She looks at Will's back, as if she's trying to say something, but she didn't say anything. There's faint light from the hallway cast on her face. Her eyes wide open. She tosses and turns. She couldn't fall asleep. She needs to find something to do.

She sits up.

INT. STUDY - NIGHT

Elena walks into the study.

Her gaze falls on the faint outline of the desk by the window. The desk was Will's, a worn-out antique piece, scattered with papers and books he claimed to be working through.

She walks over and runs her fingers over the desk surface, brushing past the edges of notebooks and folders.

She opens one drawer after another. She kneels, opens the bottom drawer.

Nothing unusual, until her hand slips behind a row of old instruction manuals.

Her fingers press against something.

She pauses.

Reaches in.

Pulls out a thin envelope - yellowed, worn around the edges. Tucked where it shouldn't be. It's the same letter as discovered by Mira.

On the envelope, she sees the name "Rebecca"

She suddenly couldn't catch her breath. Her grip tightens.

MIRA
(slowly, surprised)
Rebecca...
Three years ago...?

She opens the letter and reads it.

REBECCA (V.O.)

"Dear Will,
Forgive the suddenness of this
letter. It feels strange to write
to you after so many years. I had a
dream about you last night. I heard
if you didn't end things with
someone properly, they come back to
haunt you.
I happen to be in town for a few
days. If you'd like to meet, I'll
be at the café on Sunday.
Best, Rebecca"

She slowly sinks to the ground.

INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Will is moving around, getting ready for work, buttoning his
shirt, slipping on shoes, grabbing his keys.

On the couch, Elena sits still. She seems to be lost in
thoughts.

WILL

You're up early today.

Elena doesn't respond immediately. She hears him, but it
takes her a second to pull herself out of her thoughts.

ELENA

(faintly)

Yeah.

Will walks across the frame, straightening his collar.

WILL

Oh, there's some guy coming about
the boiler. Or the sink. I don't
know. There's a note on the...

ELENA

Will...

He pauses.

WILL

(turning)

Yeah?

A beat. Elena's eyes flick up, searching his face.

She almost says it. She almost asks.

But something holds her back.

ELENA
(shakes her head)
I forgot what I wanted to say.

WILL
Well... don't forget to pick up my
suit today.

He heads toward the door.

The door closes softly behind him.

Silence.

Elena sits motionless for a moment longer, then exhales, like she's been holding something in for days, then stands up and walks to the study.

INT. STUDY - DAY

Elena walks into the study. She sits at Will's desk and takes out the letter. She spreads out the letter from Rebecca - opened, re-read, creased in the corners from being held too long.

Elena's hands hover above the page, unsure. She exhales. Slowly.

She lays out a blank sheet of paper and picks up the pen.

She stares at the paper. Then at the envelope addressed to Will.

She looks around the room as if to check if anyone is watching.

She begins to write. The letter unfolding in her voice.

ELENA(V.O.)
"Dear Rebecca,"

She pauses and thinks.

Writes again.

ELENA(V.O.)
"Sorry it took me a while to write
back. I'd love to hear more about
your life. Where have you been?"

She hesitates, then keeps going.

ELENA(V.O.) (CONT'D)
 "As for me—well, life has been steady. Predictable in a way that should be comforting, and perhaps it is. But sometimes, I wonder about the roads not taken. Not regret, exactly. Just... curiosity."

As she's writing, she pauses sometimes and looks up to think.

ELENA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 "Tell me about the world..."

DISSOLVE TO:

INT. MIRA'S ROOM - NIGHT (PRESENT)

Mira reads the same letter. The page trembles slightly in her hands.

MIRA (V.O.)
 "...as you see it.
 Yours,
 Will"

She lowers the letter slowly. Leah's face is revealed.

LEAH
 What... the ... hell?

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. MIRA'S ROOM - NIGHT(CONTINUE)

LEAH
 So you're saying your dad's ex-girlfriend sent your married dad a letter asking him to meet up, and three years later your mom saw it... and replied, pretending to be him?

MIRA
 Yep.

LEAH
 Okay, but like—what?!
 (beat)

LEAH (CONT'D)

Did he actually meet up with
Rebecca?

MIRA

Apparently not.

LEAH

But your mom didn't know that.

MIRA

Yeah, that must be why she replied.

LEAH

Sometimes I just don't understand
straight people.

Mira is weirdly excited.

MIRA

But do you see what this is?

(beat)

This is *huge*. These aren't just
letters. This is basically a case
study in—God, I don't know—
authorship, like, impersonation?

LEAH

Or, you know... your mom lying?

MIRA

Yes, but not just lying. It's...
it's like a woman writing with
someone else's voice, because she
couldn't speak with her own.
That's... that's something.

LEAH

That's a beautiful way to describe
something really messed up.

MIRA

No, seriously—this is the whole
thing I've been circling in my
thesis. Voice, substitution,
silence—

She writes, quick, eager.

LEAH

So your mom ghostwrote your dad's
feelings to his ex, and you're
sitting here like, "Omg, perfect
case study!"

MIRA

It's not... it's material. Right?
Real, rare, *unpublished* material. I
could actually say something
original.

Leah just looks at her, skeptical.

LEAH

Girl you're so not okay.

MIRA

I'm serious. I'm not just some
undergrad quoting the theories
again. This is—this is primary
source, this is gold.

LEAH

It's still your mom.

A beat.

MIRA

I know.

(beat)

But this might actually work for my
thesis.

(beat)

I have to finish reading it. Shall
we continue?

Leah is concerned, but just lets it be for now.

INT. STUDY - DAY (2004)

Elena is surprised that Rebecca actually replied, she hurries
to open the letter. She sits at Will's desk, holding
Rebecca's letter.

REBECCA (V.O.)

"I didn't expect you to write back,
but I'm glad you did.
The world is a better place with
dorks like us who still
appreciate this long-lost art."

Elena lets out a dry laugh, she finds this super pretentious.

REBECCA (V.O.) (CONT'D)

"You asked where I've been. Let's
see—"

MONTAGE — REBECCA'S LETTER, ELENA'S REALITY.

As Elena is reading Rebecca's letter describing where she's been in the past years, Elena thinks back to what she was doing at those times. Rebecca's V.O. paired with the visual scene of Elena's life to show contrast, so the visual and the V.O. should happen concurrently.

VISUAL: INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Elena, dragging a large and heavy box into the apartment. She stumbles backward, catches herself. She looks around, no one was there to help her.

REBECCA (V.O.)

"The year after we lost touch, I lived in Paris for a while. I sketched along the Seine most afternoons, mostly faces. I liked catching people mid-moment. A mother yelling, a man scratching his beard, lovers who didn't match. I liked looking at humans. Isn't it so strange? How their lives could be running parallel to mine, just a few feet away."

VISUAL: INT. DINING ROOM - DAY

Will, Elena, and WILL'S MOTHER (50) sit at the dining table. Will's mother pulls out a small photo album. She flips to a worn photo of baby Will and turns the photo toward them with a fond smile. They all laugh. They're talking but we can't hear them.

Will's mother gestures between the photo and Will and Elena. She's urging them to have kids.

A beat of awkward silence.

Elena sips her water, eyes flicking down. Will's mother doesn't drop it. She taps the photo again, then Elena. Will takes Elena's hand and looks at her. He has stood on the same side with his mother.

Elena's smile fades.

REBECCA (V.O.)

"The next year, I was living above a bakery in Florence.

(MORE)

REBECCA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I could smell the bread and sugar
crust every morning before sunrise,
while the owner sang the same song
when he swept. I stayed in bed and
listened. Sometimes, I'd go whole
days without saying a word to
anyone. It felt... free. No one
asked when I'd settle down or
whether I was wasting my good
years. I thought that kind of
silence was a gift. It meant I
could still change my mind, that I
didn't owe anyone an answer yet."

VISUAL: INT. DINING ROOM - DAY

Elena sits across from Will at the dining table. He talks. Calm, persuasive. She looks tired. He slides something across the table. She shakes her head. He talks again. She looks down. It's the job resignation letter for her. He wants her to quit her job.

REBECCA (V.O.)
"One summer I spent in Lisbon, I
drank coffee at 4 p.m. and swam in
the ocean at midnight. The water
was always colder than I expected,
but it woke me up in the best way.
I'd dry off on the rocks, salt in
my hair, the city lights flickering
behind me like a painting. I felt
like I was living outside of time,
not moving forward, not falling
behind. Just floating."

VISUAL: INT. BATHROOM - DAY

The room is dim. Will's mother is sick and lying on the bed. Elena is kneeling beside the bed taking care of her. She looks exhausted. She adjusts a pillow beneath her head, pulls the covers up gently.

A faint cough from Will's mother.

Elena gets up again, finds the medicine bottle, pours a spoonful, and helps her drink it.

Will's mother turns her head away from the spoon. Elena waits.

REBECCA (V.O.)

"I spent a winter in Colorado, mostly alone. I found a cheap cabin near the slopes and told myself I'd finally learn to ski. I wasn't good at it, but I liked the cold in my lungs and the way everything quiets when it snows. I'd ski in the mornings, nap in the afternoons, cook whatever I felt like for dinner. No schedule, no one waiting on me. I'd fall asleep early, sore and tired in a good way. I felt like the days belonged to me."

INT. FUNERAL HOME/LIVING ROOM - DAY

Will's mother's funeral. People greet Will, shake his hand, pat his back. Elena stands beside him, still and quiet. No one greets her. She's not even looking for it. She watches the way Will nods at people, gracious and centered. Her hands are folded. She's wearing very light makeup — just enough to make her look "appropriately" solemn. She glances down.

The world moves past her like she's furniture.

REBECCA (V.O.)

"I fell in love with a woman once. We met at a Fourth of July party. She had this way of looking at the world, like everything was worth saving anyway. It didn't last. We both knew it. It ended like most things do. But some part of me never went back to who I was before. And even now, when I forget things, I remember her laugh."

Elena presses her hand on her belly, and looks at Will. We hear her words for the first time.

ELENA

"I'm pregnant."

END MONTAGE.

INT. STUDY - DAY

We come back to Elena in the study. The letter is still in her hands. She looks around, there's only silence that greets her.

She stands. Wanders toward the bookshelf.

Pulls a thin, worn volume from between two cookbooks. It's *The Snow Queen*.

She hesitates before opening it.

Inside: a dried flower petal falls out. She tries to catch it mid-air, but fails. The petal falls slowly. She watches.

CUT TO BLACK.

ELENA (V.O.)

Dear Rebecca,
Do you want to know the first
letter I have written to my wife?

FLASHBACK: INT. ELENA'S OLD LIVING ROOM (2001)

Elena and CLAIRE (21, Elena's roommate) are sitting on the couch, holding a letter, laughing together at the letter.

ELENA (V.O.)

It was after our third date.....

CLAIRE

Come on, is he serious? Drowning in
your eyes?

ELENA

(exaggerated acting)
And look at this one— "Your voice
could silence the city."

CLAIRE

He thinks he's a poet now? Wasn't
it only your third date with this
guy... wait, what's his name?

ELENA

Will.

CLAIRE

Yeah, right. What's he trying to
do?

ELENA

I don't know. A love letter?? Isn't
this a little too much?

CLAIRE

No, really! What's next? Is he gonna show up outside your window with a sonnet?

ELENA

God I hope not.

CLAIRE

But, you do like him, don't you?

ELENA

(looking for the right words)

I mean...he's so different from anyone I have ever met. You know those guys I work with? They're all...

(she frowns, looking for the right words)

flashy and... trying to win something. Promotions, bonuses, whatever. But Will he... He talks about poetry, films that nobody cares about anymore.

CLAIRE

When have you ever liked this kind of stuff?

ELENA

I don't. I mean—

(she hesitates, something soft in her expression)

I didn't. But he doesn't expect me to. He just... leaves the door open. And he doesn't say those things to impress anyone. He's just... him.

A KNOCK at the door.

Elena and roommate freeze. Exchange a look.

CLAIRE

You're kidding.

ELENA

No. He wouldn't.

Elena opens the door.

Will stands there, awkwardly holding a book-*The Snow Queen*. He's slightly breathless, maybe rushed here. He holds it up. His eyes light up when he sees Elena.

WILL

Hey. I, uh... I brought you something.

He hands her the book.

WILL (CONT'D)

I found this in a secondhand bookshop and... I don't know. It reminded me of you.

ELENA

(playfully)

You think I'm the Snow Queen?

WILL

No! Not- I mean, yes, but not like *that*.

ELENA

(still teasing)

So I'm cold and terrifying?

WILL

(earnest, fumbling)

No, I mean-yes, but in a good way!

(beat)

It's just... the story feels cold at first, sure. But there's this part in the middle where everything's kind of sad and then... suddenly you feel this flicker of real warmth, like you weren't expecting it.

ELENA

(mock serious)

You're really doubling down on calling me cold.

WILL

No-I'm saying you're the flicker!

(beat)

You're all quick and sharp and then out of nowhere you say something a little silly and real, and it's like... the sun.

ELENA
(smirking)
That's a very elaborate way to say
it.

WILL
Yeah, well. I panic when I like
someone.

They both laugh.

ELENA
You're ridiculous.

Elena looks at him. She's smiling, wholeheartedly. You can
just tell, she's falling in love.

ELENA (V.O.)
(slowly)
And three months later, we were
married.

FLASHBACK ENDS.

TRANSITION BY SHOWING THE SAME BOOK NEXT TO ELENA

INT. STUDY - DAY

We come back to Elena in the study. She pauses her writing.
We can see from her face that this happy memory brought her
joy and pain at the same time.

ELENA (V.O.)
Marriage is work, everyone told us
this.

MONTAGE: INT. DINING ROOM - NIGHT

The same dinner party as before - same setting, same people.

ELENA (V.O.)
But I never knew you would always
feel like you're failing no matter
how hard you try.

The sound is muffled. Just the clinking of silverware and the
drone of voices behind glass. We stay with Elena.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL)
I watch her at these dinners.

Elena smiles. Nods politely. The room laughs around her, but she's not laughing.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL) (CONT'D)
She says all the right things. She
laughs when she's supposed to. But
her eyes...

We hold on her eyes.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL) (CONT'D)
...they're always somewhere else.

Grace gestures animatedly with her fork. Will chats with someone across the table. He never once looks at Elena.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL) (CONT'D)
I wonder if she hears them at all.

Elena pushes food around her plate. She glances at Will. He keeps talking.

Quick cuts:

- A calendar on the fridge, marked with reminders.
- A to-do list on a whiteboard: "CALL PLUMBER." "PICK UP EGGS."
- A post-it on the microwave: "DISHWASHER LEAK AGAIN?"

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL) (CONT'D)
We used to talk about how much we
love each other. Now we talk about
what to eat. What to fix. Whether
to replace the carpet.

INT. LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Will is asleep in front of the TV. Elena stands at the doorway, looking at him.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL)
I don't know when, but at some
point, I stopped reading the books
I used to enjoy. Maybe it's just
life.

INT. GROCERY STORE - DAY

The same grocery scene as before. Elena moves through the aisles. Efficient, practiced. Vanilla extract. Chicken.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL)
She takes care of everything. She
knows exactly where things are.
What we need. I don't even ask.
She's good at it. But I don't know
if she's happy.

INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

The same bedroom scene as before. Will is already in bed,
turned away. Elena stands in the doorway, just watching him.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL)
I tell her she did a good job. But
I'd say the same thing to a
colleague. A waiter. I don't know
what else to say.

Elena slowly walks in, sits on the edge of the bed.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL) (CONT'D)
I've stopped knowing how to talk to
her.

INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

The same living room scene as before, where Will was getting
ready to work. Elena is sitting on the couch.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL)
The silence came gradually. At
first, it was just tiredness. A
long day. A headache.

INT. HALLWAY - DAY

Elena and Will pass each other in the hallway. No words.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL)
But then... it became the air
between us. Thick and expected.
Like furniture.

END MONTAGE.

INT. STUDY - NIGHT

We come back to Elena writing the letter at Will's desk.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL)
Maybe writing this is the only way
I remember who we used to be.

She looks out the window.

ELENA (V.O.) (AS WILL) (CONT'D)
I miss her.

FADE OUT.

INT. STUDY - NIGHT (PRESENT)

Mira is surrounded by open folders, highlighters, a legal pad of notes. One of Elena's letters lies carefully unfolded beside her. She's underlined passages. Post-it tabs jut out from every corner. She looks anxious and absorbed in the letters.

She scribbles a note. Something clinical. Leah is next to her, also holding a letter.

LEAH
Did you know your parents were this
unhappy?

MIRA
I don't know if unhappy is the
right word. They just... weren't
really talking. Isn't that what
most parents are like?

LEAH
Not mine. Mine argue A LOT. But
also sing karaoke together on
Tuesday nights.

Mira shrugs. She gestures at a page.

MIRA
This phrasing is interesting,
right? Like, how she frames the
past tense, it's like she's
grieving someone who's still alive.

Leah stares at her. She's trying to get Mira to talk about her parents.

LEAH
And your dad was like this? Like,
sweet? Poetic?

MIRA

I guess? It's so weird. He was always just... dad.

(beat)

I didn't even know he liked art.

LEAH

Yeah. What happened to him?

MIRA

I don't know. I guess he got... practical. Grew up.

(beat)

LEAH

You know last summer I did that internship. I told myself I would explore the city, learn a new language, go out and meet people or whatever. But everyday after work I just felt so... tired. I'd come home and just... melt into the couch. I watched, like, seven seasons of the worst dating show known to man.

MIRA

Which one?

LEAH

Doesn't matter. They were all terrible.

(beat)

I didn't even like them. I just didn't have anything left in me.

(beat)

I guess it's not that easy to not become a boring adult.

They both go silent for a beat.

LEAH (CONT'D)

When did your mom pass?

MIRA

(slightly distracted)

Umm, when I was ten.

LEAH

Weird how I've known you for seven years and I've only heard you talk about her for like, twice.

MIRA

(avoidant)

Yeah... we weren't really that close.

(beat)

She did everything she should do, dropping me off, picking up groceries. Sometimes she forgot stuff. Like to pick me up after dance. She said sorry, and I said it's fine, but I'd sit there for like... an hour, waiting for her.

(beat)

One time I got sick – like, throw-up-in-the-middle-of-the-night sick – and she came in and stood there like she didn't know what to do. I remember thinking, *shouldn't she know?*

But then she made pancakes the next morning. Like that was the answer.

(beat)

She wasn't mean. Just not very... there.

Sometimes I'd ask her something and she'd say "one sec" and then forget I even asked. So I just... stopped asking.

(Mira shrugs)

She wasn't the best mom.

LEAH

I'm sorry.

MIRA

No it's fine.

(beat)

It's been a long time.

Mira keeps writing down things.

LEAH

okay, you're doing the thing again.

MIRA

What thing?

LEAH

Dissecting her. But with... cute stationery.

MIRA

It's useful. For my thesis.

LEAH
It's also how you hide in plain
sight.

Leah tosses a sticky note. It bounces off Mira's forehead.

LEAH (CONT'D) (CONT'D)
You're such a nerd.

Mira flicks it back. Leah sticks it on her own forehead.

LEAH (CONT'D)
You know silence isn't neutral.

MIRA
What?

LEAH
Silence. It's not just what happens
when people run out of things to
say. It's a choice.

MIRA
Okay therapist.

LEAH
No really. When I first started
dating Cathy, I used to shut down
whenever things got hard. Say I
needed space, pretend I wasn't
angry. Because if no one was
yelling, then maybe we were fine.
But she wouldn't let me. She'd
follow me into the kitchen. She'd
say, "Nope. We're doing this." And
we'd talk. It wasn't always pretty.
I remember once she said, "You know
what, you're not as smart as you
think you are."

MIRA
Rude.

LEAH
It was! But she was right. And
after that, we could look at each
other. And know what was actually
there, not just the version we were
hoping for.
(beat)
Now we fight. Sometimes we yell.
But we always talk.

Leah looks down at Mira's notes again. A beat of hesitation.
Then:

LEAH (CONT'D)
What are you hoping to find?

MIRA
Patterns.

LEAH
Of?

MIRA
Like, how women write letters?

Silence. The air becomes a little tense.

LEAH
Do you want to sleep soon?

MIRA
I want to finish this first. You go ahead.

Leah nods. She lingers for a second, then turns to leave.

LEAH
You know, I think sometimes you study people so you don't have to talk to them.

MIRA
You're really not afraid to say anything huh.

LEAH
Good night Mira.

She exits. Mira is left alone. She looks up from what she was doing. She knows she was just avoiding and she's confused too. The silence around her is dense.

EXT. CITY STREET - LATE AFTERNOON (2004)

Elena exits a corner store, a fresh envelope already torn open in her hand.

She reads while walking.

REBECCA (V.O.)
Last weekend I stayed at a cabin where the shower only did freezing or scalding. No in-between.
(MORE)

REBECCA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 I stood there for way too long,
 trying to convince myself the cold
 would eventually feel okay. It
 didn't. I just got used to not
 feeling my skin.

Elena slows. Stops entirely by a tree. The city moves around her, muffled.

REBECCA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 I don't know your wife, but the way
 you wrote about her, it reminded me
 of that, of someone living in the
 cold and calling it normal.
 (beat)
 I love reading what you write.
 Write me again.

Elena folds the letter carefully, as she begins to walk again, she couldn't hide her smile. Somebody appreciates what she writes. She finally has her voice. She's finally seen. The world is more alive now. VIVALDI'S "SPRING" builds gently. The world hums. She watches everything.

MONTAGE: ELENA RUNNING ERRANDS, CONTINUOUS WALK - DAY

Elena is moving, observing, doing everyday errands, the kind women do without being noticed. Now, her internal voice is alive. Elena's voiceover consists of moments she writes to Rebecca as she notices the small things. Rebecca's voiceover responses are from her letters, creating a rhythmic, asynchronous exchange. The tone is light, intimate, and quietly funny. The world coming into color as they begin to see and be seen through each other. It's about women seeing the world and not having had anyone to tell, until now. The ordinary becomes vivid, because it is finally shared.

EXT. FRUIT STAND - DAY

Elena picks up an apple from a mountain of them and takes a close look at it.

ELENA (V.O.)
 Dear Rebecca,
 Full disclosure, I have never had a
 real reason for choosing a certain
 apple.

REBECCA (V.O.)
It's kind of like dating. I kept
inspecting them, waiting to feel
certain. Maybe I'll end up choosing
someone by chance.

EXT. OUTSIDE OF DRY CLEANER - DAY

Elena exits, plastic-wrapped clothes draped over her arm. A
stray hanger jabs her in the chin.

ELENA (V.O.)
I always wondered why we pay so
much for the delicate clothes. If
they're so expensive, shouldn't
they fall apart less?

REBECCA (V.O.)
I think that's the point. Humans
pay this much just because they
secretly want to be held
responsible.

EXT. MAILBOX - DAY

She drops a letter into the mailbox, hesitates, then drops
another.

ELENA (V.O.)
There's a moment after you let go -
a half-second of panic - like, what
if I wasn't ready to send it?

REBECCA (V.O.)
Every letter sent is a leap of
faith. Until you remember you wrote
it at 2 a.m. in a weird mood.

EXT. OUTSIDE CORNER STORE - DAY

Elena exits holding a bunch of celery and a single lemon.

ELENA (V.O.)
Today I carried groceries like I
was in a French film.

The lemon rolls away.

ELENA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Until the lemon rolled away.

REBECCA (V.O.)

If a lemon escapes, let it. Some
days, even citrus deserves freedom.

A plastic bag drifts along the sidewalk. Elena watches it
float, hover, veer off again.

ELENA (V.O.)

A bag floated past like it couldn't
decide if it wanted to leave or
stay. I followed it for a while.

REBECCA (V.O.)

I know it's dumb, but sometimes I
feel like a plastic bag. Floating
around, getting stuck on fences.
But it's different when someone
actually sees you. Makes you feel a
little less ridiculous.

Elena buys roses from the florist by the street.

ELENA (V.O.)

Sorry about all this nonsense I'm
writing. I keep meaning to write
about something big, but I only
ever notice the small things.

REBECCA (V.O.)

The small things are the big
things. We just get told otherwise.
Yours, Rebecca.

Elena folds the page. Slides it into an envelope.

She closes her coat against the breeze and keeps walking as
golden light hits the sidewalk.

MONTAGE ENDS.

INT. KITCHEN - EVENING

Elena is humming while arranging the roses in the vase on the
dining table. She's in a very good mood.

Will enters, setting down his bag. He notices the flowers.

WILL

Roses?

ELENA

Yeah, thought the kitchen could use
some color.

WILL
They're nice.

Elena looks up and glances at him.

ELENA
Dinner's almost ready. I tried that
mushroom thing from that book.

WILL
The French one?

ELENA
Yeah.
(Beat)

Will nods and sits down and begins to read newspaper.

ELENA (CONT'D)
You remember you used to bring me
roses?

WILL
Of course I do.

ELENA
I never asked. Why is it always
roses?

WILL
Oh, it's just from that book I gave
you. *The Snow Queen*.

ELENA
The children's book?

WILL
Yeah. There's this line about how
the roses knew everything that had
happened. Even what people tried to
forget. I guess I thought... love
should be like that.

ELENA
That's beautiful.
(she moves closer to will)
Why don't you read anymore.

WILL
(point at the newspaper)
I am reading now.

ELENA
You know what I mean.

WILL
I've just been busy.

ELENA
The same reason why you don't bring
me flowers?

WILL
If you want flowers I could bring
some home.

ELENA
That's not what I'm saying.
(beat)
Do you even know what I do all day?

WILL
(he's confused by Elena's
sudden questioning)
What?

ELENA
What I did this week. What have I
been doing all day while you're
working.

WILL
You went to the farmer's market?

ELENA
Jesus. I'm trying here, Will. I'm
really trying. But I feel like
you're not trying to talk to me.

WILL
I didn't know you wanted to talk
about something. I'm not a mind-
reader.

ELENA
It's not just... something. It's
everything. You didn't care enough.

WILL
Okay. What's going on?

ELENA
(conjures up the courage
to say it)
Why have you never talked to me
about the baby?

Will goes still. He's surprised that Elena brought this up.
Elena stares at him.

ELENA (CONT'D)
We lost a baby. And you said
nothing.

WILL
I—
(pause)
I didn't know how.

ELENA
It's been *eight months*.

WILL
What do you want me to say?

ELENA
I can't tell you what to say.
(beat)
Explain to me.

WILL
What?

ELENA
Explain what you thought would
happen when you ignored it. Ignored
me.

WILL
(takes a deep breath)
Because it hurt to say anything.

ELENA
Well what do you think I felt?
(beat)
You think it didn't hurt? For me to
have something lived inside me...
and then not anymore?

WILL
I thought I was protecting you.

ELENA
By saying nothing?

WILL
By not making it worse.

ELENA
You think silence doesn't make it
worse?

WILL
So now I'm the jerk for grieving
wrong.

ELENA
You didn't grieve at all. You moved
on.

WILL
That's not fair.

ELENA
You go to work. You come home. You
eat dinner and fall asleep in front
of the TV. And you left me to clean
up all the messes and the hurt
alone.

WILL
Do you want me to cry every night?
Would that make it better?

ELENA
I just want you to not act like it
didn't happen. I want you to at
least TRY.
(silence)
I need to go for a walk.

She takes her coat and walks out. Will didn't say anything.

EXT. STREET - EVENING

Elena walks without a direction. She's not crying. Just
stunned. Hollowed out.

She sits on a bench, and takes out a notebook and a pen.

She opens it. Stares at a blank page. The pen poised for a
while. She then begins to write.

ELENA (V.O.)
Dear Rebecca,
There's something I haven't told
you. Something we never really told
anyone. We lost a baby.

FLASHBACK: INT. BATHROOM - DAY

Elena crouches by the tub, arms wrapped around her knees.

ELENA (V.O.)
It happened in the spring. Quietly.
At home. She didn't scream. She
didn't call anyone. She just waited
for it to end.

INT. KITCHEN - LATER

Will walks in with a paper bag. Elena stands by the sink. Her sleeves are still rolled. She's cleaned everything.

ELENA (V.O.)
By the time I got home, she had
already cleaned the floor.
She asked if I wanted tea. I asked
if we had milk.

Will takes the milk. He doesn't look at her. Elena nods faintly. Then turns away.

ELENA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I didn't know what to say. And I
think she didn't want to hear it.
At least, that's what I told
myself.

BACK TO: INT. PARK BENCH - NIGHT

Elena stares at the letter. She hesitates, then adds:

BACK TO: INT. BATHROOM - DAY

Elena is still sitting in the tub, staring into the void.

ELENA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
The worst part is... She wasn't
even sure if she wanted the child.
There were thoughts she wouldn't
admit, even to herself. And when it
happened... she wondered if thinking
it was enough to make it true.

BACK TO: INT. PARK BENCH - NIGHT

She pauses. The pen trembles.

ELENA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I don't know how to forgive her for
that. Or how to tell her there's
nothing to forgive. Or maybe I just
haven't said it.

She looks up. Her eyes are damp, but she's not crying.

ELENA (V.O.) (SLOWLY)
Yours, Will.

She seals the envelope, quietly.

And sits there a moment longer, before rising.

EXT. BEACH - DUSK (PRESENT)

The lake stretches wide and still, waves lapping in and out like breath. Mira and Leah sit close together on the beach but not touching, the sky dimming around them. Wind combs Mira's hair across her face, but she doesn't move it. She's holding a letter. It has already been read.

MIRA
She lost a baby.

Leah nods.

MIRA (CONT'D)
She thought she killed it. Because
she didn't want it enough.

MIRA (CONT'D)
(quietly)
She never wanted to be a mother.

LEAH
Mira...

MIRA
I mean it. I don't think she wanted
it, or me. Any of it.

Leah turns to her gently. Mira doesn't look back. She's staring forward, eyes unfocused, as if remembering something.

MIRA (CONT'D)
It's not even... it doesn't hurt
the way it should. It just...
explains things.

LEAH
That's not nothing. That's huge.

MIRA
But it makes sense.

LEAH
You're trying to make everything
make sense again.

Leah hesitates for a beat.

LEAH (CONT'D)
Can I ask you something?

Leah pulls something from her bag.

LEAH (CONT'D)
I found this in your drawer.

She hands Mira a birthday card. The date on the card says 2023. Eight years after her mother had "died."

Mira doesn't say anything.

LEAH (CONT'D)
You told me she passed when you
were ten, but this was written
eight years after she had "passed".
(beat)
Why didn't you tell me the truth
before?

MIRA
I didn't know how.

LEAH
You told me she died.

MIRA
That was easier.

LEAH
Easier for whom?

Mira looks at her.

MIRA
She... she didn't die. She left.
It's... complicated with my mom. I
didn't know how to feel let alone
say it out loud.

LEAH
I'm your best friend. You're the
first one I came out to. We're not
"likes and happy birthday texts"
kind of friends. You don't get to
hide behind "it's complicated."

MIRA
I'm sorry. What do you want me to
say?

LEAH
Anything real.

MIRA
That's easy for you to say.

LEAH
What's that supposed to mean?

MIRA
You don't have a mom that left you
when you were 10.
(beat)
It's just, you know what you want.
You feel things and
actually say them. I... I'm not
like that. I don't know what I'm
feeling half the time.

LEAH
That's not easy for me either.
That's not easy for anyone.
(beat)
You think I don't have stuff that I
need to deal with? My grandma- my
favorite person- still calls Cathy
my "special friend."
But I deal with it. I--

MIRA
No you don't get it. She left,
Leah. She just left. And people
always said, "Oh, there's two sides
to every story." And I thought
maybe it was me. Maybe I cried too
much. Maybe I didn't smile enough.
(beat)
You walk around like it's just...
easy. Like being honest is just
something people are. You feel
things and then you say them and
somehow people still stick around.

LEAH
Mira-

MIRA
I don't want to be *too much*, or *too*
cold, or *too messy*. I don't even
know who I am without editing
myself mid-sentence.
(beat)
And you - you want me to talk. You
push and push.
(MORE)

MIRA (CONT'D)

And I just keep thinking if I tell
the truth, it'll ruin everything.
That you'll see whatever she saw
and decide I'm too much too.

She's trembling now, the words finally come out.

MIRA (CONT'D)

I thought if I studied her long
enough, if I wrote the perfect
thesis, maybe I could fix
something. But I can't even say to
her face: *you left me*. You made
pancakes the next morning like it
fixed something, like I should be
grateful you showed up for
breakfast.

Beat. She laughs once – bitter.

MIRA (CONT'D)

God. And then she sends me a
birthday card. Like nothing
happened. Like "Hey, sorry I
disappeared for half your life –
here's a drawing of balloons."

She's quiet, breath catching. Leah looks at her. A faint
smile slowly on Leah's face.

LEAH

See, you're saying it out loud now.

MIRA

What?

LEAH

Your feelings. I know you're
screaming at me, but I'll take it.

MIRA

(laughs in disbelief)
Yeah, I guess I am.

LEAH

Now say more.

MIRA

Like what?

LEAH

Anything that you never got to say
to her.

MIRA
It's stupid.

LEAH
It's not.
(gestures out)
Come on, scream it. The lake won't
tell anyone.
(beat)
You know what? Fine. I'll start.

She steps forward, facing the water. A breath. Then yells:

LEAH (CONT'D)
I HATE GROUP PROJECTS!

Mira laughs, caught off guard.

LEAH (CONT'D)
AND I'M TERRIFIED I'M GOING TO BE A
MEDIocre PERSON WHO PRETENDS TO BE
FINE FOREVER!

Leah looks at Mira.

LEAH (CONT'D)
Your turn.

Mira looks around. She's skeptical but decides to try.

MIRA
(quiet at first, the gets
louder)
WHY DID YOU LEAVE ME?--
(beat)
WHERE DID YOU GO?--
(beat)
HOW ARE YOU?--

A pause. Then Mira wipes her eyes. A dry laugh.

MIRA (CONT'D)
Gosh I feel like the girl in one of
those indie films I used to laugh
at.

LEAH
Nobody hates them more than me but
they might be onto something.

They laugh — breathless, emotional. A beat of real calm.

LEAH (CONT'D)
So, was that the last letter?

MIRA
No. There's one more.

They look at each other.

EXT. OUTSIDE A COFFE SHOP PATIO - DAY (2004)

Elena walks along the sidewalk, alone. She slows as she passes a busy patio. Laughter, chatter, clinking cups.

A voice behind her:

CLAIRE (O.S.)
Hey!

Elena turns, Claire, her old roommate from before is sitting with a small group.

ELENA
Oh my god.

They hug, briefly, out of politeness. Elena is kind of awkward throughout.

CLAIRE
Oh dear I haven't seen you in... I don't know, three years?

ELENA
Yeah it's been so long.

CLAIRE
(talking to the group)
This one, was my best friend and roommate from when we first started working. She was AMAZING. She basically hit the top of the leaderboard straight out of training.
(then turns to Elena and starts talking to her)
How have you been? Are you still working at the same place?

ELENA
Oh-no, I... I left a while ago. Took some time off.

CLAIRE
(not being completely honest)
Ah. That's great. Self-care, right?

Elena smiles awkwardly.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
Oh, and your husband—Will, right?

ELENA
Yeah. Will. He's good.

A silence. The group at the table laughs at some joke. Roommate glances back.

CLAIRE
You should join us! We're celebrating Lucy's promotion.

ELENA
Oh, I can't. I'm on my way to...pick up something. But it's so good to see you.

CLAIRE
Let's catch up properly sometime?

ELENA
Definitely.

They hug again. Roommate is already half-turned back to the table.

Elena walks on. She seems lost after being reminded of what she once had and now has lost.

The voices fade behind her.

INT. KITCHEN - LATER THAT DAY

The house is quiet. Still. A single warm light pools onto the kitchen table. Elena walks in holding a letter—Rebecca's latest reply. Her fingers tremble as she carefully opens it.

REBECCA (V.O.)
Dear Will,
I read your letter twice, and it gave me heartache just reading it. I'm so sorry.
I don't know if this would be of any comfort, but what I've been telling myself when things don't go my way is: if something never happened, maybe it wasn't meant to be. Or maybe it just wasn't the right time.

(MORE)

REBECCA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 Sometimes, we make choices without
 realizing we've made them at all.
 And those choices open up a new
 life for us.
 Thank you for telling me. I mean
 that. I'm here. Still.
 Yours, Rebecca

Elena stands frozen in the kitchen. The kettle behind her
 begins to boil—loud, shrill. She doesn't notice.

She blinks hard, reading again. Her finger traces the last
 line. Then, quietly—

ELENA
 (softly)
 I'm here. Still.

She sinks into the kitchen chair. The whistle of the kettle
 continues. Finally, she rises, shuts it off. Silence again.

INT. STUDY - DAY (CONTINUED)

She walks to the cabinet, takes out the box, inside is
 Rebecca's letters, bundled.

She brings the stack to the table. Sits. Her hands hover
 above a blank page.

She looks over at the roses that have wilted and begins to
 write.

ELENA (V.O.)
 Dear Rebecca,
 Hi.
 I don't really know how to begin
 this, so I'll just say it—I'm not
 Will. Will is my husband. I'm
 Elena.
 (This is the first time we
 hear her name. Her own
 name. She finds it
 through writing.)

ELENA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 I know this must be strange to
 read. I found your letter in our
 house by accident, and I don't know
 why I wrote back pretending to be
 him. At first, I thought I just
 wanted to know if he had gone to
 see you. But then your letters kept
 coming, and I kept replying.

Visual: As she writes, we see flashes: her carefully folding laundry alone, watching dishes pile up, and that moment outside the coffee shop with her old roommate's laughter echoing behind her as she walks away, hollow.

ELENA (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Sometimes, I wonder if I could have been you, if I had made different choices. And thank you for listening, for talking to me. Even though you may have been talking to Will.

I don't know if you'll ever want to write back after this, but selfishly I hope you do. Because I have never felt so seen.

Yours, Elena.

Her handwriting is shaky at first, but she keeps going.

A close-up of her signing her name at the bottom of the letter. She pauses before the final period. Then, she presses the pen down, punctuates it, and exhales.

In the dark window beside her, she sees her own reflection, faint but clear. She stares back at it for a long time.

She folds the letter. Seals it.

She opens the window. A breeze stirs the loose pages on the table. She breathes in deeply—first time in years.

FADE OUT.

INT. STUDY - NIGHT (PRESENT)

The room is dim. Mira is sitting on the floor beside a small open box, the last letter now resting in her hands. She has read it.

She touches at the final signature: Elena.

MIRA

(quietly to herself)

The words your husband never said to you, you heard from your husband's ex-girlfriend...

She slowly sets the letter down, eyes scanning the now-empty box. Something unsettles her. She reaches in again. Nothing.

She rises, scans the room. Pulls open drawers, boxes. and walks to the shelf.

She runs her fingers over the spines of old books. Then pauses at one: *The Snow Queen*.

She pulls it out and slowly opens it. We can't see what's inside, only Mira's face. She stares at it—breath caught, still.

INT. BUS - DAY

Mira and Leah sit side by side in an intercity bus. Mira is sitting upright while Leah has her head leaned against the window. Mira looks a little tense and nervous.

LEAH

Are you sure this is a good idea?

MIRA

No.

Beat.

MIRA (CONT'D)

But I think I need to see her.

Mira takes out *The Snow Queen* and flips to the first page. Elena's handwriting fills the inside cover.

LEAH

I still can't believe your mom wrote a whole letter to Rebecca inside a children's book.

Mira smiles, and looks down at the writing.

ELENA (V.O.)

Dear Rebecca,
You sent all the letters back. I know you're mad at me.

Note: from this on, it should be cuts between the 2004 timeline and present timeline. Mira tracing Elena's footsteps.

EXT. SMALL TOWN STREET - DAY (2004)

Elena steps off a bus holding a paper with Rebecca's address and looks around.

ELENA (V.O.)

So please don't get angrier when I tell you this: I actually went to see you.

It's a quiet town. She walks down a tree-lined street, past a florist with buckets of lilies and a foggy bakery window.

ELENA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Your town was smaller than I
imagined. Slower. A place where
people probably knew each other's
names.

CUT BACK TO

EXT. SMALL TOWN STREET - DAY (PRESENT)

Mira and Leah walk on the same street as Elena. They stop outside a building.

MIRA
I think I want to go up myself.

LEAH
I'll walk around and wait for you.

Mira nods. Then she takes a deep breath like she has made a decision. She walks in.

CUT BACK TO

EXT. REBECCA'S DOOR (2004)

Elena stands before a door. Knocks. REBECCA (25) opens it. We see Rebecca standing there, barefoot, wrapped in a worn sweater. She seems like she just woke up. Elena is stunned.

ELENA (V.O.)
It was indeed you, flesh and blood.
No longer just ink on a page or a
voice in my mind.

REBECCA
(a little annoyed)
Who's this?

Elena hadn't thought this far ahead.

ELENA
Oh... I'm here to... I work for the
dog shelter. Have you thought about
adopting a dog?

REBECCA
Oh, probably not. I already have a
dog. He's been keeping me busy.

ELENA (V.O.)

I hadn't expected that. I used to imagine if I were you, I wouldn't take on any responsibility, or anything to hold me in place. I would just be free.

ELENA

Oh really? How long have you had him?

REBECCA

Two years, I think.

ELENA (V.O.)

I should've left. But I just wanted to talk to you.

ELENA

How has it been, keeping him?
(she's looking for words)
And, uh, what do you do for work?
You know, for... survey purposes.

REBECCA

It's not easy sometimes. He's been keeping me here, away from traveling. But it's probably what I need right now. Besides, I like my job - I'm working as a barista in the café across the street. And he's too cute to be left alone for long.

ELENA

How long have you been living here?

REBECCA

Gosh... I don't know. Around two years now?

Elena takes a long look at Rebecca. We see Rebecca's face closely.

ELENA (V.O.)

You seemed... good. You seemed really good.

ELENA

Thank you. I hope everything works out.

REBECCA

Of course. You, too.

Rebecca closes the door.

CUT BACK TO

EXT. REBECCA'S DOOR (PRESENT)

Mira stands in front of the same door. She hesitates, the knocks.

A WOMAN (around 45) opens the door, slightly impatient.

MIRA
Umm, hi, sorry to bother you. Does
Rebecca live here?

WOMAN
She doesn't. She moved a while ago.

Mira is a little lost.

WOMAN (CONT'D)
Anything else I can help you with?

MIRA
Oh, do you know where she moved to?

WOMAN
(shrugs)
No idea.

MIRA
Oh, umm, still thank you.

The woman shuts the door like she couldn't wait to do so.

Mira is left standing there, a little stunned.

INT. CAFE - DAY (PRESENT)

Mira walks into the cafe.

ELENA (V.O.)
I stopped by the cafe you were
working at.

Mira looks around the space. A woman in her fifties was chatting with the barista, her laughter carrying over the soft hum of conversation. A man in paint-stained jeans sat in the corner, sketching something in a notebook. A couple was sharing a slice of cake.

We see Rebecca in Elena/Mira's imagination, behind the counter, preparing coffee, chatting with costumers.

ELENA (V.O.) (CONT'D)

I imagined you here. I imagined you standing right behind the counter, by the window. How you rented a little place, found a job here, learned to be a barista from scratch. Probably got scolded by the manager for steaming the milk wrong or dismissed by customers when you fumbled with change. How you got better. How you learnt the way the beans smelled in the morning, the quiet satisfaction of a perfect pour.

Mira walks out.

EXT. SUBURBAN STREET - DAY (CONTINUED)

Mira roams on the street. Everything feels lighter now.

ELENA (V.O.)

I stayed in your town for a while.

CUT BACK TO

INT. CAFE - DAY (2004)

Elena walks into the cafe.

BARISTA

Same as yesterday?

She nods. A soft smile.

ELENA (V.O.)

I thought maybe I could properly introduce myself to you.

EXT. OUTSIDE THE DOG SHELTER - DAY

Elena lingers outside the shelter. She sees a "Help Wanted" sign in the dog shelter window. Stares at it.

ELENA (V.O.)
Maybe I could really go work at the
dog shelter.

CUT BACK TO

EXT. OUTSIDE THE DOG SHELTER - DAY (PRESENT)

Mira lingers outside the dog shelter, watching what's inside.

CUT BACK TO

EXT. PARK BENCH - DAY (2004)

Elena is sitting on a park bench. She watches children play.
She writes something in a notebook. Stops. Crosses it out.

ELENA (V.O.)
*Maybe I could stay here forever,
and never go back.*

EXT. BUS STOP - DAY

Elena carries a luggage, stands up and waves to gesture at
the bus.

ELENA (V.O.)
But I didn't stay.

WHEN THE BUS DRIVES BY, IT'S MIRA WE SEE

EXT. BUS STOP - DAY (PRESENT)

Mira is standing at the bus stop. Leah is across the street,
waiting. They see each other and smile, the kind of eye
contact that says, *Oh, there you are*, without needing a
single word.
Mira walks to her.

EXT. PARK BENCH - DAY

They sit side by side on a neighborhood park bench. They may
be eating something. Around them, the small park hums with
life — kids shriek and chase each other near a swing set, a
pair of joggers pass by chatting, a woman under a tree flips
through a paperback novel.

A child's bicycle clicks past on the sidewalk, its wheels
humming. Mira watches it briefly before turning back to Leah.

LEAH
So... How did it go?

MIRA
Rebecca doesn't live there anymore.

LEAH
No way! She moved? After twenty years?

MIRA
(laughs, a little self-deprecating)
That was kinda stupid of me.

She reaches into her backpack and pulls out *The Snow Queen*.
She turns it slowly in her hands.

MIRA (CONT'D)
I always wonder why my mom loved this book so much.
She read it to me so often, it's the only one I really remember.

LEAH
What's it about again?

MIRA
Oh, two best friends, Kai and Gerda. One day, a shard of magic glass got in Kai's eye, and suddenly everything looked cold and ugly. He forgot how to care. Then the Snow Queen took him away.

LEAH
And Gerda went after him?

MIRA
Yeah. Alone. No one else even remembered he's gone.
(beat)
She travelled through forests, palaces, gardens. Everyone she met told her to stay. Rest. Forget. And promised her freedom. But she didn't.

LEAH
Why not?

MIRA
Because the world she wanted wasn't the easy one.
(MORE)

MIRA (CONT'D)

(beat)

She found Kai. He didn't remember her. She cried, and the tears melted the ice in his heart. He came back. The end.

LEAH

So love saved him?

MIRA

I used to think that too.

(beat)

But I read it again yesterday, and... I think it's not just love.

(beat)

The most difficult part is that she kept going. She refused to abandon what she chose, even when everyone told her it was foolish and it stopped making sense.

(beat)

She got her freedom.

Mira closes the book gently. Her thumb lingers on the cover. A moment.

MIRA (CONT'D)

I used to be so angry. Like she owed me a better version of herself. A braver one.

(beat)

But... I think maybe she gave what she could, while she could.

(beat)

That doesn't make it okay. But she's human.

(beat)

I'm not going to wait for her anymore.

Mira gently closes *The Snow Queen* and puts it back into her bag.

MIRA (CONT'D)

Oh! Good news. I'm almost done with my thesis.

LEAH

(relieved, teasing)

Oh thank God. I was worried it was going to end us.

MIRA

Yeah. I just don't know how much it means to me now.

(beat)

Would you rather... be a balloon drifting above everything... or one of those that comes down too low and may get caught in the branches?

LEAH

God, this game again?

MIRA

Come on just answer.

LEAH

You go first.

MIRA

(think for a beat)

I used to think the high-up one. Stay untouched. Float above the mess.

(beat)

But I don't think I want that anymore.

LEAH

No?

MIRA

No.

(beat)

I think I'd rather be the one that comes down. Even if it gets tangled.

(beat)

But gosh I still don't know what I'm gonna do.

(beat)

LEAH

Remember you used to ask me how I could be so sure all the time?

MIRA

Oh, yeah. I hated that about you.

LEAH

Oh well then. I wasn't. I was faking it.

MIRA

What? So these seven years we have together is just a lie?

LEAH

(laughs)

Like when I applied to work at the shelter? I had no idea what I was doing. I was terrified of hating it. Or of being terrible at it. But I just... said yes. And showed up the next day. And the next.

(beat)

I just... chose. And kept choosing.

MIRA

Even when it didn't make sense?

LEAH

Especially then.

(beat)

So what if you get tangled, or popped by some ...kid with sticky fingers and a pencil he sharpened down to the metal-

MIRA

That's right, go on.

LEAH

You'll bounce back. Maybe a little rougher-looking, but you'll fly just as well.

MIRA

Don't you feel like everything matters too much? Like one wrong step and I ruin the whole thing?

LEAH

That's just what it feels like when you're staying still.

MIRA

What do you mean?

LEAH

Move. Even a little. The world shifts with you.

She reaches out and takes Mira's hand, gentle but certain, and pulls her up. They stand for a moment, watching what's in from of them.

Then they look at each other, laughing lightheartedly. The world spans in front of them, life going on.

INT. KITCHEN - DAY

It's the same scene as the first scene. Somewhere in between dreams and reality, warm light spills across the floor. The rose that fell over is lying on the dining table. Mira sits at the table, looking at the letter in *the Snow Queen*.

Elena moves through the kitchen — her back to us, to Mira. She's rinsing a cutting board. Quiet domestic sounds: the hum of the fridge, the soft clatter of dishes, running water.

She reaches for a towel, dries her hands, wipes the counter. Nothing dramatic, just small, steady movements. The kind of care that's easy to miss.

ELENA (V.O.)

Rebecca, did I ever tell you I had a daughter?
She's already two, but some days I still can't believe it.
It's like suddenly there was this little person watching me, waiting for me to be someone I'm not sure I know how to be.

Elena continues with the chores, moving around the kitchen. Mira looks at Elena, quietly. She doesn't interrupt.

ELENA (V.O.) (CONT'D)

No one tells you how much of yourself you'll lose.
Or how much of yourself you'll meet again —
strange, clumsy, tender parts.
I don't think I was ready. I feel like I'm messing up all the time.
I was scared I'd pass on all the wrong things.
Still am.
(beat)
The other night, she asked me if the world was going to be okay.
Just like that. We were brushing our teeth.
She had toothpaste on her chin.

Mira smiles faintly. Watches her mother wipe down the sink.

ELENA (V.O.)

I think I said something about how
people are trying their best.
But the truth is, I wanted to tell
her I don't know.
That I'm still confused and I'm not
a good enough person to answer her
questions.
I hope the world is kind to her,
but it's usually not the case.
But there's one thing I do know:
I want her to stay in this maybe-
not-okay world anyway.
Not perfect, not fearless,
but here.
Yours, Elena

Mira picks up the rose and puts it back into its place. She
steps forward. Elena turns.

They look at each other.

A quiet moment. Neither speaks.

Mira moves to the sink. Picks up a dish. Washes it beside her
mother.

They work in silence – together, side by side.

THE END.